Relationships in ecosystems

There are many types of relationships between living things in an ecosystem. Some relationships place two living things against each other (for example, the relationship between an animal that hunts and eats another animal). Other relationships can **benefit** one or both organisms.

Mutualism is a type of relationship between different living things that benefits both. For example, a small fish that eats a special type of algae lives amongst a group of bigger fish that have this algae growing on their skin. The smaller fish cleans up the skin of the bigger fish by nibbling at the algae. Both types of fish benefit. The little fish gets fed, and the bigger fish gets rid of its skin problem.

☞ **1** What is mutualism? Use the words in the box to write a definition.

a	relationship	living things	benefit	between	where
	organisms	describes	mutualism	both	

2 Are the following statements true or false?

a)	Mutualism does not benefit small organisms.	True	False
b)	Relationships always benefit one organism and not the other.	True	False
c)	Living things can sometimes live together in a way that helps both things.	True	False
d)	Mutualism only exists amongst certain fish populations.	True	False

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ISBN 978 1 92571 064 9

Relationships in ecosystems CONT'D

3 Complete this passage about mutualism by inserting the words from the word bank.

A certain fish that has algae growing on its _____ lives with a group of _____ fish that eat the _____ off the skin . This relationship enables the larger fish to keep its skin from being completely _____ by the algae. The relationship between these fish is an example of _____, where both living things _____ from the relationship: the small fish get _____ and the larger fish gets regularly cleaned.

Word bank

skin

covered

food

algae

mutualism

benefit

smaller

4 Read Question 3 again, and then unscramble the words in brackets to complete this passage.

There is a third (ganisorm) _____ mentioned in this example: the (galea) _____ that lives on the (knis) _____ of the larger fish. This is an example of another type of (shiplaretion) _____, called a parasitic relationship.

5 Are these relationships an example of mutualism? Circle yes or no.

a) A lybia crab, or pom-pom crab, lets sea anemones grow on its claws. The anemone gets carried around and can find food more easily. When a predator approaches, the crab waves the stinging sea anemones like pom-poms to defend itself.
Yes No

b) Barnacles attach to the underside of a baleen whale. The barnacles feed well on the many nutrients that are available there. The whale is unaffected by the barnacles.
Yes No

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